Colour for your website and business

Yes – but more as a friendly spark than as the main voice.

In business orange is red's friendly sister. It is **warm** and **energetic**, but it does not command. **It invites you closer.** At the same time it is the colour that shouts “watch out” on the road. That is why it is good to know what you are promising before you let it into a logo, a website or an advert.

By itself, though, it **does not attract customers** like a magnet. It can help **catch** attention and create **a welcoming impression**, but what still decides is mainly **what you sell**, **to whom** and **how well** it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Orange can say, for example

“Come closer.” “It's pleasant here.” “You can try it.” “It's simple.”

- **Friendliness and warmth.** It does not feel as serious as red. It invites conversation.
- **Energy and joy.** It suits where you want to awaken appetite and enthusiasm.
- **Creativity.** It is linked with ideas, playfulness and unconventionality.
- **Visibility.** It is easily visible, and that is why it is used in safety.
- **Approachability.** It is often credited with accessibility and friendliness. Not everywhere and always, but brands use it when they want to seem relaxed.

Depending on the shade, though, it can also feel different. A rich orange is **more active** and **louder**, terracotta feels **earthy and crafted**, peach and apricot **warm and soft**, saffron **warming and festive**.

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Simple tips

As a second colour

It works brilliantly as an accent next to a calm base (blue, grey, cream). It is the second button, not the main alarm.

Shade by role

Rich for energy and action, peach and apricot for warmth, terracotta for craft and earthiness, saffron for warming festivity.

Cultural context

In Ireland orange can recall political division, in India saffron means spiritual renunciation, in the Netherlands it is used to celebrate. Before you set out into the world, find out what orange means with you and with them.

Colour blindness

About 1 in 12 men has trouble telling red and green apart. Do not use these two colours as the only difference between two things.

Not the whole website

Large rich orange areas tire and put customers off.

Legibility

White text on orange often lacks enough contrast. Try dark lettering or a darker shade.

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Professions where it is a Yes

Café, bistro, baking and a shared table

Orange can support a story of warmth, food and hospitality. Try ceramics, packaging or part of the lettering. For a small quiet café I would choose a different form than for fast food. A guest may want to sit for a while and does not need to feel from the packaging that they have to be at the next stop within three minutes.

Ceramics, craft and natural materials

Terracotta or rust can accompany clay, wood, textiles and handwork well. **Why.** The shade can connect to the real material and the experience of it, you do not have to invent a story the product does not have at all. But let the work itself stand out. When an orange website swallows all the photographs of ceramics, the colour has got a bit too excited about its own exhibition.

Movement, dance, leisure and social events

A stronger orange can be suitable where you want to invite people to an activity, a meeting and an informal atmosphere. Give it a clear task on the poster. One motif, name or important piece of information. If you highlight everything, the organiser will be loud even on paper.

Body care and personal projects

A soft apricot can be pleasant for a brand that wants to feel personal and warming. Try it next to real photographs and natural materials. But watch whether the result captures your work. If you offer deep stillness, a radiant orange website full of movement may promise a different experience.

Professions where it is a No

This is not a ban for whole fields. What decides is the interplay of colour, text, photographs and setting.

- **Accompaniment in grief and crisis help.** A pronounced cheerfulness can feel out of place towards what a woman comes with. A soft warm detail may work better than a whole radiant page.
- **A space meant for deep rest.** I would first test large rich areas. If they keep drawing attention over and over, they can go against the intended impression of stillness.
- **A brand based on discretion and quiet elegance.** A sharp orange can drown out the subtlety of the offer. A muted shade or a small accent may be more precise.
- **A place where orange already marks an operational notice.** More orange decoration can visually drown an important signal.

Give important information clearly legible dark text.

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Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer, and ask “What would you expect from such a place or service?” **Is the offer visible, or mainly the orange?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that orange means joy.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

Examples from the market

You know orange from shops, adverts and the street. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **Hermès (luxury fashion)**
  According to a story the company itself tells, Hermès switched to orange boxes in 1942 because its usual packaging was not available. The story comes from the company and has not been independently verified. The colour, though, became its trademark because the company held to it long and consistently.

- **Orange (telecommunications)**
  The telecommunications brand Orange was created in Great Britain on 28 April 1994 in cooperation with Hans Snook and the agency Wolff Olins. It was meant to feel welcoming, simple and friendly. The logo deliberately does not look like a fruit. Since 2013 the original France Télécom has also been called by that name.

- **easyJet (airline)**
  The founder Stelios wanted a colour the airline would “own”. He chose orange (Pantone 021C, today “easyOrange”), which the company has as a trademark. The planes are recognisable from afar.

- **Nickelodeon (children's television)**
  The children's channel has used orange and white since 1984. The orange “splat” came only around 2003 and originally referred to the slime gags from the Canadian show *You Can't Do That on Television*.

What they have in common is that orange carries a simple message. **Close, visible, playful.** And it is mostly not everywhere, only where it is meant to stand out.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, on customers and on how consistent the brand is. Take it as an idea to test, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources; for Hermès it is the company's own story.

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